yalty

The BJP sheds inhibitions about wooing erstwhile royals to advance their political cause. For the royals, it is a chance to regain political and cultural relevance

By RAHUL NORONHA



REGAL REDUX
Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav at the Rajwada cabinet meeting in Indore, May 20

Madhya Pradesh chief minister Mohan Yadav is known to have a penchant for offsite cabinet meetings. Whenever he is in a mood to indulge his cabinet colleagues or send out a political signal, the venue shifts from the cabinet room on the fifth floor of Vallabh Bhavan—the state secretariat in Bhopal. On May 20, it was the Rajwada, the 200-year-old palace of the Holkars, the erstwhile rulers of Indore, that was the venue. CM Yadav sat in an ornate chair, while his cabinet colleagues were arranged in a manner that evoked the impression of a Holkar Durbar. The meeting was to discuss the plans for the upcoming 300th birth anniversary of Maharani Ahilyabai Holkar, and the commemorative events to be held in her honour.

The enactment of this piece of royal theatre was not lost on anyone. "There's nothing objectionable about celebrating an icon like 'Devi' Ahilyabai," a source said. "But it's the royal makeover of an otherwise routine cabinet meeting that stood out." This is not all. The BJP-ruled MP has also launched *'Virasat se Vikas'* (heritage to development), a programme to revive the legacies of Rani Durgawati, Rani Avanti Bai, Ahilyabai, Raja Bhabhut Singh, as well as the legendary King Vikramaditya.